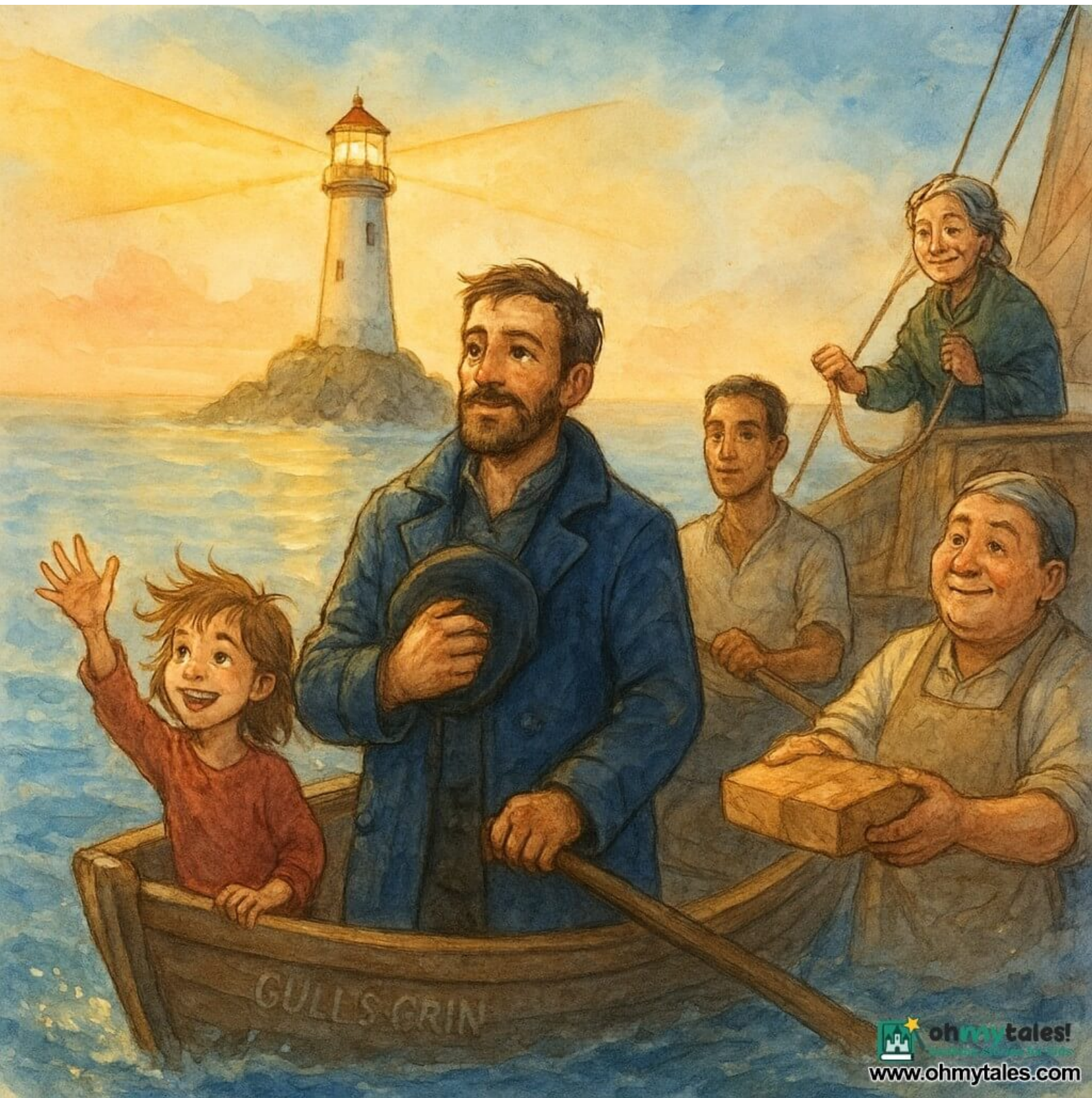


The Secret Lantern Route: Captain Bram and the Brave Lighthouses

Pirate story • 11-12 years old



Chapter 1: The Map That Wouldn't Sit Still

Captain Bram Oxbow wasn't the kind of pirate who collected crowns or kidnapped governors. He collected lighthouses.

Not the lighthouses themselves, of course—those were far too heavy, and the last time he tried to “borrow” a stone step, it fell through the deck and nearly sank the soup pot. No, Bram collected something better: names, sketches, and exact positions of lighthouses that marked the Secret Lantern Route, a hidden path through reefs and fog banks that only the bold—or the foolish—would attempt.

On the morning it began, the sea was the color of pewter, and the wind tasted like salt and lemon peel. The Gull's Grin rocked gently while Bram knelt by a barrel, smoothing a crinkled chart.

The chart refused to behave.

It kept curling back up as if it had its own opinions.

“Stay flat,” Bram muttered, pressing it down with one hand and a tin mug with the other. “I'm not arguing with paper before breakfast.”

A laugh came from above. “Maybe it's shy,” called Lina, the youngest lookout, hanging upside down from the rigging like a cheerful bat. “Some maps don't like being stared at.”

Bram squinted up. “Lina, you're going to fall.”

“Not today,” she said, and then promptly slipped.

She did not fall far—Jory caught her by the collar with a smooth, practiced move. Jory was the ship's navigator, quiet as a shadow and twice as smart. He set Lina

back on her feet without making a big deal of it, which only made Lina grin wider.

“See?” Lina chirped. “Not today.”

Bram cleared his throat. “Crew! Listen up.”

Boots thumped. Ropes creaked. A few gulls screamed as if offended by the idea of teamwork. The crew of the Gull’s Grin gathered near the mainmast: Jory with his compass and calm eyes, Lina with wind-tangled hair, Old Nessa with her knitting needles (she claimed she could knit a net faster than anyone could tie one), and Patch, the cook, who had flour on his nose like a clown who’d lost a fight with a bakery.

Bram tapped the chart. “We’re going to chart the Secret Lantern Route.”

Patch raised a hand. “Is that the one with the reefs shaped like teeth?”

“Those are the nicer parts,” Bram said.

Old Nessa sniffed. “Secret routes are always secret for a reason. Usually because they want to eat you.”

“True,” Bram admitted. “But this one is worth it. The Lantern Route is marked by a chain of lighthouses—old, rare ones. Some are abandoned. Some are... peculiar. And the only way to sail it safely is to know each light, each rhythm, each warning.”

Jory leaned closer. “You want to list them. All of them.”

Bram smiled. “Exactly. Names, bearings, sketches. A proper register. If we do this, we’ll have a guide that no storm can erase and no rival crew can bluff.”

Lina’s eyes shone. “And then we’ll be the only pirates who can sail through the fog without crashing like a drunk walrus!”

Patch nodded solemnly. “Respectfully, that would be an improvement.”

Bram rolled the chart flat at last, using a dagger at each corner. On it was a faint dotted line through dangerous waters, with tiny lighthouse marks—some clear, some smeared like the ink had been licked by a sea monster.

“First light,” Bram said, tracing the line. “Spindlewick. We start there.”

A sudden gust snapped the sails. The Gull’s Grin turned her nose toward open water like a dog scenting adventure.

Bram stood and tucked the chart into a waterproof tube. His heart beat with a familiar mix of nerves and excitement. Courage wasn’t the absence of fear. Courage was steering straight through it—preferably while making a joke so your knees didn’t show how much they shook.

“Raise anchor!” he called.

The chain rattled, the crew heaved, and the ship began to move.

The Secret Lantern Route waited.

Chapter 2: Spindlewick and the Light That Stuttered

By nightfall, fog rolled in thick as porridge. The sea went quiet, the way it does when it’s thinking.

“Spindlewick should be close,” Jory said, peering at the compass. “If the current isn’t lying.”

Currents, Bram believed, were the most polite liars in the world. They didn’t shout or brag. They simply smiled and moved you three miles off course while you weren’t looking.

Lina clambered up to the bow, squinting. “I don’t see anything but fog and... more fog.”

Patch, holding a lantern, whispered, “I once saw a fog so thick you could butter it.”

Old Nessa snorted. “Stop talking about food. You’ll summon hungry spirits.”

Bram put a hand on the rail. The wood was damp and cool. He listened. The ship creaked softly, like an old friend clearing its throat.

Then—blink—blink-blink—blink—

A faint white light flickered ahead, not steady, not smooth, but stuttering as if it couldn’t decide whether it had the energy to shine.

“There!” Lina pointed. “Like a nervous firefly!”

Bram’s grin spread. “Spindlewick Lighthouse. Mark the rhythm.”

Jory counted under his breath. “One... two... fast-fast... pause... one. Repeats every seven beats.”

Bram pulled out his notebook, its pages covered in careful handwriting and quick sketches. He wrote: SPINDLEWICK—WHITE—STUTTER:
1,2,fast-fast,pause,1.

The fog thinned just enough for the lighthouse to appear: a tall, thin tower of pale stone, perched on a rock that looked like a whale’s back. It truly did resemble a spindle—long and narrow—hence the name.

As the Gull’s Grin drew nearer, a small boat pushed off from the rock. A figure in a rain cloak rowed toward them, oars slicing the water with sharp, angry splashes.

“Visitors,” Old Nessa murmured. “Or trouble with manners.”

The boat bumped the hull. The cloaked figure looked up, face shadowed.

Bram leaned over. “Evening! Lovely fog, isn’t it? Very... foggy.”

The figure pushed back the hood. A woman with soot-smudged cheeks glared up at them. “Are you here to steal my oil?”

Patch gasped. “We’re not that sort of pirate!”

Bram held up both hands. “No stealing. We’re lighthouse... enthusiasts.”

The woman blinked as if he’d said they were enthusiastic about rocks. “You... what?”

Jory spoke gently. “We’re making a register of the Lantern Route. We only need the name, the light pattern, and any warnings.”

The keeper’s suspicion didn’t vanish, but it wobbled. “Warnings, yes. The lamp’s acting strange. The wick keeps fraying. The light stutters. I’ve been alone here three weeks trying to fix it.”

Lina leaned over Bram’s shoulder. “That sounds lonely.”

The keeper’s eyes flicked to Lina, then away, as if loneliness was something embarrassing to admit. “I don’t need pity. I need steady flame.”

Bram’s voice softened. “We’ve got hands. And spare wick. Patch, don’t we?”

Patch patted a sack. “Wick, string, and something that might be cheese if you don’t ask questions.”

The keeper hesitated. Then she sighed, a long breath that smelled of smoke. “Fine. But if you try to take anything, I’ll throw you in the sea.”

Bram beamed. “Fair. I’ll try not to take the sea either.”

They went ashore by rope ladder, boots slipping on wet stone. Inside the lighthouse, the air was warm and oily. The lamp room at the top was a circle of glass panes, smeared by salt. The flame inside the lantern housing sputtered like it had a grudge.

Bram rolled up his sleeves. “Show us the trouble.”

The keeper—who finally introduced herself as Mara—handed him a frayed wick. “It burns uneven. Like it’s chewing itself.”

Jory examined the lamp’s gears, the part that rotated the lens. “The mechanism is catching. That could make the light jerk.”

Patch, miraculously careful, cleaned soot from the vents. Lina held a lantern and made faces at her own reflection in the glass until Old Nessa hissed, “Stop haunting yourself, child.”

Working together, they trimmed the wick, adjusted the gears, and cleared the vents. It took patience and steady hands. Twice Bram’s fingers slipped, and he had to breathe slowly, resisting the urge to curse like a cannon.

After an hour, Mara struck a new match and lit the lamp.

The flame rose, steady and bright.

The light now blinked with a clean pattern: blink—blink—blink—pause—blink.

Mara stared, stunned. “You fixed it.”

Bram shrugged. “We’re good with stubborn things. Ropes. Ships. Maps. People.”

Her mouth twitched, almost a smile. “Thank you.”

Lina reached into her pocket and held out a tiny paper boat folded from a scrap of old chart. “For company,” she said. “It doesn’t talk much, but it’s loyal.”

Mara took it carefully, as if it were something fragile and valuable. “I’ll keep it.”

Bram wrote the updated rhythm in his notebook and added a note: KEEPER: MARA. WICK FRAYS. MECHANISM CATCHES. NOW STEADY.

Back aboard the Gull’s Grin, fog curling around them again, Bram felt warmth in his chest that wasn’t from lantern oil.

Friendship, he thought, was like a lighthouse. It didn’t chase away all the dark, but it gave you something to steer by.

“Next light,” he said, looking at the chart. “Cindercap.”

Patch groaned. “That sounds like it’s on fire.”

Old Nessa nodded. “Or it wants to be.”

Chapter 3: Cindercap and the Ashen Reef

Cindercap didn’t appear as a tower at first.

It appeared as a smell.

Smoke—faint but unmistakable—slipped through the night air. The fog broke into ragged strips, and the moon showed its sharp edge like a coin half-hidden in a pocket.

Jory leaned over the rail, eyes narrowed. “There’s a reef line here. The chart marks it, but the markings are old.”

Bram held the spyglass to his eye. Far ahead, a reddish light pulsed like a slow heartbeat.

“That’s Cindercap,” Bram said. “Red lantern. Not welcoming.”

Lina shivered. “Why would a lighthouse be red? Isn’t that the ‘stop or you die’ color?”

Patch said, “Maybe it’s festive.”

Old Nessa snorted. “Yes. A festive warning of doom.”

As they approached, the sea changed texture. The waves weren’t rolling anymore; they were twitching. Dark shapes lurked just beneath the surface, like the backs of sleeping sharks.

“Reef,” Jory said. “Ashen Reef. Volcanic rock, sharp as broken plates.”

Bram’s mouth went dry. One wrong turn and the Gull’s Grin would be torn open like a tin can.

“Slow her down,” Bram ordered. “Lina, to the crow’s nest—call depth. Patch, ready the long pole. Nessa, get your netting—if we snag, I want something to haul us free.”

“Aye!” came the chorus.

The crew moved fast, and not because Bram was loud. They moved because they trusted one another. Trust was an invisible rope, stronger than any hemp.

Lina climbed, quick and sure. “Depth is dropping! Ten fathoms... nine... eight!”

Bram stood at the helm, hands steady even though his stomach tried to climb up his throat. He watched the pulse of Cindercap’s light: red—pause—red—red—long pause.

Jory leaned in, pointing. “See that line of foam? That’s the current splitting around the reef. We ride the left edge.”

Bram nodded. “If the current doesn’t change its mind.”

“It will,” Jory said. “But not yet.”

The ship eased forward. The reef’s jagged teeth appeared in the moonlight—black spikes with white froth hissing around them. The sound was like a thousand kettles boiling.

Patch braced a pole against the side, pushing gently when rocks loomed close. Old Nessa tossed a weighted net over a protruding stone to test distance, then yanked it back with a grunt. “Too close,” she muttered. “Sea’s trying to bite our ankles.”

Bram’s palms sweated. The wheel felt slick.

Then the wind shifted.

Not a dramatic gust—just a subtle turn, like someone whispering a different idea into the sails.

The Gull’s Grin drifted right, toward the sharpest cluster of rocks.

“Hard left!” Bram shouted.

The crew sprang. Jory grabbed a line, yanked the sail angle. Patch shoved with the pole so hard his face went pink. Lina shouted from above, “Seven fathoms! Six!”

The hull scraped something.

A sickening sound—wood against stone.

Bram's heart punched his ribs. "Damage?"

Old Nessa leaned over, eyes fierce. "Not through. Just a kiss from the reef. And the reef has ugly lips."

Bram let out a breath he hadn't known he was holding. "Don't let it kiss us again."

They made it through the tightest gap just as a stronger wind roared down the channel, as if disappointed it hadn't gotten to wreck them.

Cindercap's lighthouse finally came into full view: a squat tower of dark brick with a cap of blackened metal. Smoke curled from vents near the top, and the glass of the lantern room glowed red.

As they drew alongside the rock it stood on, Bram saw why.

The lighthouse's base was built near a vent in the earth. Warm air shimmered over the stone, and fine gray ash dusted the steps.

"Volcanic," Jory murmured. "That's why the reef is like knives."

A figure appeared at the door: a thin man with goggles pushed up on his forehead. He waved frantically. "Hey! You there! Don't come closer!"

Bram cupped his hands. "We're not planning to. We like our hull unshredded."

The man stumbled down a few steps, then stopped as if the rock might move under him. "The heat's been rising. The lamp's oil is thinning. If it boils, the lantern could burst."

Patch winced. "Bursting lantern oil sounds... very not good."

Bram called, "We have spare oil and a cooling coil—copper. Let us help."

The man blinked. “You’re pirates.”

Bram nodded. “Yes. The helpful kind. Confusing, I know.”

Jory added, “We’re recording the Lantern Route. But we won’t leave you with a dangerous light.”

The keeper—his name was Sato—led them carefully up to the lantern room. The heat hit like opening an oven. The metal housing of the lamp was warm enough to make Bram yank his hand away.

Sato showed them a narrow pipe where hot air rose from below. “It’s worse at night. The vent breathes.”

Bram studied it. He couldn’t fight a volcano, but he could out-think a problem.

“We can redirect the heat,” Bram said. “Patch, fetch the copper coil. Jory, help me rig it around the pipe like a sleeve. Lina, keep water coming—slowly, not splashing. Nessa, tie those knots tight. No slipping.”

They worked in a sweaty blur. The copper coil, wrapped and secured, acted like a heat sink. Water dripped over it in a controlled trickle, cooling the metal without shocking it. The lantern housing cooled enough that the oil stopped trembling.

Sato’s shoulders slumped in relief. “That might actually hold.”

Bram wiped his brow. “It will. At least long enough for you to get proper parts.”

Jory counted the light’s new rhythm: red—red—pause—red—long pause.

Bram wrote it down, then added: WARNING: ASHEN REEF. HEAT VENT. KEEP OIL COOL.

As they left, Sato handed Bram a small jar of gray ash. “From the last big burp,”

he said. "For luck."

Patch whispered, "Does volcano luck explode?"

Bram tucked the jar into his coat anyway. "We'll keep it away from the soup."

Back on the ship, the crew looked tired but buzzing, like they'd swallowed sparks.

Lina leaned against the rail beside Bram. "Why do you care so much about the lighthouses?"

Bram watched Cindercap's red pulse fade behind fog. "Because someone built them to save strangers. Even in the worst places. That's... brave."

Lina nodded slowly. "So we're like... lighthouse pirates."

Patch perked up. "Can I make a flag with a lantern on it?"

Old Nessa said, "You can make a flag with a potato on it if you stop nearly getting us killed."

Bram laughed, and the sound flew out over the water, bold as a sail.

"Next," he said, voice turning serious. "The hardest one. Gloomglass."

Jory's eyes sharpened. "The one with no keeper."

"And no mercy," Old Nessa added quietly.

Chapter 4: Gloomglass and the Borrowed Dark

Gloomglass wasn't on any friendly map. On Bram's chart, it was drawn with a

smudge and a note in faded ink: LIGHT SWALLOWS LIGHT.

Patch stared at that note and whispered, “That’s rude.”

The fog thickened again, swallowing sound. Even the gulls seemed to have decided this was not a place for jokes.

They sailed slower than a sleepy turtle. The sea grew strangely smooth, as if holding its breath. Bram felt it in his bones: this was a place where the world listened.

Then they saw it.

A lighthouse made of dark stone and black glass, standing on a narrow isle like a finger pointing accusingly at the sky. Its lantern room was not glowing.

It was... dimming.

Around it, the air looked wrong. The stars above it seemed fainter, as if someone had rubbed them with a dirty cloth.

Lina hugged herself. “Captain... I think the lighthouse is stealing the night.”

Jory’s voice was careful. “No, it’s bending light. Like smoke in a bottle.”

As the Gull’s Grin neared, their own lanterns seemed to shrink, flames turning weak and bluish.

Patch lifted his lantern and frowned. “Hey! My light’s getting stage fright.”

Old Nessa’s knitting needles clicked nervously. “I don’t like a place that can reach out and pinch your fire.”

Bram forced a grin that felt tight. “All right. We’re not here to admire the architecture. We’re here to register it—and make sure it doesn’t get anyone

killed.”

“How?” Lina asked.

Bram didn’t have a full answer, which was uncomfortable. He liked plans. Plans were like pockets: you could keep your courage in them until you needed it.

They anchored at a safe distance. Bram, Jory, and Lina took the skiff. Old Nessa stayed aboard with Patch, ready with rope and a very loud opinion.

The water near Gloomglass was oddly cold. Bram’s oar dipped in and came up slick, as if the sea itself had turned cautious.

They reached the rock. The lighthouse door stood slightly open.

“That’s inviting,” Lina said. “Like a mouth.”

Bram drew his cutlass—not to threaten, but to feel less like a nervous sandwich. “Stay close.”

Inside, the air smelled like wet stone and old storms. Their footsteps echoed too loudly, then faded as if the building swallowed sound. Spiral stairs wound upward, the walls lined with glass panels so dark they reflected only vague shapes.

Halfway up, Lina whispered, “Do you think it’s haunted?”

Jory replied softly, “If it is, it’s a smart ghost. It picked a place no one visits.”

At the lantern room, they found the problem.

The lens assembly—a huge circle of glass prisms—was coated in a thin film of something black and oily. It crawled across the glass like spilled ink that hadn’t decided to stop moving.

Bram leaned in, then jerked back. “That’s not dirt.”

Jory’s eyes narrowed. “It’s like... soot that grows.”

Lina held up a small candle she’d brought. The flame dimmed as she got close to the lens, as if frightened.

Bram’s mind raced. “If the lens can’t focus light, the beacon fails. Ships hit the rocks. But why would soot keep coming back?”

Jory examined the vents and the lamp housing. “There’s no proper airflow. It’s sealed too tight. Smoke has nowhere to go, so it coats the lens.”

Lina pointed. “Look—those vents are blocked with glass plates. On purpose.”

Bram’s jaw tightened. Someone had modified the lighthouse. Not just neglected it.

“Why would anyone do that?” Lina asked.

Bram thought of rival pirates who liked wrecks because wrecks meant cargo. He thought of greedy merchants who wanted secret routes to stay secret. His stomach turned.

“We open the vents,” Bram said.

Jory hesitated. “If we do, the smoke will escape. The light might work. But if the building’s been sealed for years, opening it could pull air through too fast—feed the lamp, flare it up.”

Bram nodded. “So we do it carefully. One plate at a time.”

They worked in tense silence. Bram loosened the first glass plate, hands steady by sheer will. Jory held it, easing it away. A soft sigh of air slipped through, like the lighthouse was breathing out.

The black film on the lens trembled.

Lina whispered, "It's moving."

Bram forced his voice to stay calm. "It's just soot reacting to airflow."

But when the second plate came off, the black film wriggled faster, sliding down the lens as if trying to hide.

Jory's voice sharpened. "That's not normal soot."

The film gathered into a thicker blot, then stretched like a living shadow.

Lina squeaked. "Captain—!"

Bram didn't run. He wanted to. His legs suggested it loudly. But he planted his boots and did what courage sometimes looks like: staying in place while your brain yells at you to leave.

He remembered the jar of volcanic ash in his coat. Ash was fine grit. If the shadow was clinging to the lens, grit might break its grip.

He pulled out the jar, yanked the lid, and flung a cloud of ash across the glass.

The shadow recoiled, thinning, breaking apart into smoky strands.

Jory grabbed a cloth and wiped hard, scraping the oily residue away while Bram sprinkled more ash. Lina, quick-thinking, opened the last vent plate a crack, just enough to keep air moving without making the lamp surge.

The shadow fought like a stubborn stain, but teamwork is an excellent scrub brush.

Finally, the lens shone clear—cold, bright glass catching what little light the room had.

Bram exhaled. “Now—ignite the lamp.”

Jory lit it carefully. The flame rose, brighter than expected, then settled into a steady burn.

The lens began to turn.

A beam of pale white light cut out into the fog—strong, sharp, alive.

Outside, the stars above Gloomglass seemed to brighten again, as if the night had been given back its stolen coins.

Lina laughed shakily. “We un-haunted it!”

Bram managed a grin. “Or we cleaned it. Either way, I’d like to never meet living soot again.”

Jory watched the light pattern through the rotating lens. “It flashes once—long—then two quick. Repeats.”

Bram wrote: GLOOMGLASS—WHITE—LONG, QUICK, QUICK. NOTE: VENTS BLOCKED. BLACK FILM—USE ASH/GRIT.

As they descended, Bram paused at the door and glanced back. The lighthouse beam swept the interior walls briefly, making the dark glass gleam like wet midnight. For a moment, Bram felt as if the tower was watching them leave—silent, stern, and somehow grateful.

Back in the skiff, Lina leaned toward Bram. “You weren’t scared?”

Bram snorted. “I was terrified. My courage was in my pocket, and it tried to crawl out.”

Jory allowed a small smile. “You used your head.”

“And you used yours,” Bram said, nodding at Jory. “And Lina used her heart. That’s how you beat a problem that thinks it’s bigger than you.”

When they returned to the Gull’s Grin, Old Nessa squinted at them. “Did you survive the creepy lighthouse?”

Patch held out a steaming mug. “Drink this. It’s tea. Or possibly revenge.”

Bram took it, grateful for the warmth. “We survived,” he said. “And we made the light shine.”

Old Nessa sniffed. “Good. Because the next one is the last marker on your chart.”

Bram’s fingers tightened on his notebook. “The final lighthouse,” he murmured. “Brightsalute.”

Lina’s eyes widened. “That’s a real name?”

Patch grinned. “Sounds polite.”

Jory looked thoughtful. “Or like a signal.”

Bram stared into the fog ahead. “Either way, we finish the register. And then we go home—with every crew member still aboard.”

The sea, as if listening, gave a low, rolling sigh.

Chapter 5: The Storm That Tried to Erase Everything

The storm arrived like an uninvited guest who kicked the door down.

Wind slammed the sails. Rain lashed the deck in icy ropes. The sea stopped

being water and became a moving argument.

“Reef the mainsail!” Bram shouted, voice almost torn away. “Keep her nose into it!”

The Gull’s Grin climbed a wave, then slid down the other side so fast Bram’s stomach tried to stay behind. Lightning ripped the sky open, showing the world in a harsh white blink: rigging like spiderwebs, faces strained and wet, the horizon snapped into jagged lines.

Lina clung to a line, hair plastered to her forehead. “Captain! The chart tube!”

Bram’s heart lurched. The tube—his lighthouse register, his notes—was strapped to the rail, but the strap had come loose, whipping like an angry eel.

Bram lunged, boots skidding. A wave slapped the deck, cold as a bucket of ghosts. The tube slid, then bounced toward the scuppers.

Jory grabbed Bram’s belt from behind. “Don’t!”

Too late. Bram reached for the tube and felt the ocean’s pull like a giant hand. For one wild second, he teetered over the edge, seeing nothing but churning black water.

Patch yelled, “Captain! If you fall in, who’s going to boss us around?”

Old Nessa snarled, “Hold him, you idiots!”

They did. Jory held Bram’s belt. Lina grabbed Bram’s sleeve with both hands, teeth clenched. Patch, somehow, pinned Bram’s boot with his own, as if feet could be anchors.

Bram’s fingers closed around the tube.

He yanked it back with every muscle he had. The crew hauled with him, and

Bram collapsed onto the deck, hugging the tube like it was a baby made of paper and stubbornness.

Rain hammered his face. He spit seawater and laughed once—short, breathless, half-mad.

“See?” he coughed. “Paper can be... very dramatic.”

Jory’s eyes were hard with worry. “That was reckless.”

Bram wiped his face. “Yes.”

Lina’s voice shook. “But you didn’t let it go.”

Bram looked at their hands still gripping his sleeve, his belt, his boot. “Neither did you.”

Another wave crashed. The ship groaned.

Bram forced himself up. “We make it through. Together. Jory, keep us on heading. Lina, watch for any light—any sign of Brightsalute. Patch, keep everyone warm and upright. Nessa... do your terrifying knot magic.”

Old Nessa’s grin flashed like a blade. “Now you’re speaking my language.”

The storm tried to erase the world. It tried to blur the line between sea and sky, between courage and panic. But the Gull’s Grin fought like she had pride.

Hours stretched. Bram’s arms ached from the wheel. His thoughts narrowed to simple things: breathe, hold, listen.

Then, between lightning flashes, Lina screamed—not in fear, but in triumph.

“LIGHT! Off the starboard bow!”

Bram's head snapped up. Through the rain, a beam cut the darkness—not white, not red, but a warm gold that felt like seeing a hearth from far away.

Brightsalute.

The storm still raged, but that beam didn't wobble. It swung in a wide arc, steady as a promise.

Jory shouted over the wind, "If we follow that arc, it'll guide us through the shoals!"

Bram's throat tightened. A lighthouse wasn't just a tower. It was a friend you hadn't met yet, holding up a lantern in the worst weather and saying, Here. This way.

"Steady!" Bram roared. "Chase the light!"

The Gull's Grin turned, and for the first time all night, the sea's fury seemed to miss them by inches instead of feet.

The light swept again—gold, unwavering—leading them forward.

Chapter 6: Brightsalute and the Beacon's Goodbye

By dawn, the storm limped away, leaving the world rinsed clean.

The sea turned a deep blue, wrinkled with leftover waves. The air smelled sharp and new, like wet rope and fresh beginnings. The crew looked as if they'd wrestled a cloud and lost—soaked, exhausted, but grinning.

Brightsalute Lighthouse stood on a low island of pale sand and smooth stone. Unlike the others, it looked cheerful: whitewashed walls, a blue door, and a lantern room gleaming in the early sun. Even the gulls circling it sounded less

angry, more like they were gossiping.

As they anchored in calm water, Bram's shoulders finally unclenched.

A figure stood on the shore, hand shading their eyes. When the crew rowed in, the figure revealed himself to be an elderly keeper with a neat gray beard and a coat patched in so many places it looked like a quilt that had become a person.

He raised a hand in greeting. "You're alive," he called. "Good. The sea has been in a terrible mood."

Bram stepped onto the sand, boots squishing. "We noticed."

The keeper's eyes twinkled. "Name's Hollis. Welcome to Brightsalute. Most pirates don't visit unless they're lost."

"We're not lost," Bram said, then glanced back at the ocean. "We were... temporarily misplaced by weather."

Hollis chuckled. "That's what the sea calls 'lost.'"

Bram pulled out his notebook and pencil. The pages were wrinkled at the edges but readable. "I'm Captain Bram Oxbow of the Gull's Grin. We're registering the lighthouses of the Secret Lantern Route. We've marked Spindlewick, Cindercap, and Gloomglass. You're the final light."

Hollis's expression softened. "A register, is it? That's... a generous sort of piracy."

Patch whispered to Lina, "Told you we're confusing."

Hollis waved them toward the lighthouse. "Come in, dry out. The kettle's on. And before you ask—yes, you can copy the light pattern. It's the only pattern I've ever been proud of."

Inside, Brightsalute smelled of tea, lemon biscuits, and lamp oil in the best possible way. Bram felt his stomach rumble so loudly that Lina giggled.

Hollis poured tea into mismatched cups. "So. Why do it? Why risk reefs and storms for a list?"

Bram held his cup, letting the warmth seep into his fingers. He thought of Mara alone on Spindlewick, Sato sweating in the heat, the stolen darkness at Gloomglass. He thought of his crew hauling him back from the sea, not letting him disappear.

"Because people depend on these lights," Bram said quietly. "Even pirates. Especially pirates. And because... knowing the route means we can help others through it, not just ourselves."

Jory nodded. "Information can be a lifeline."

Lina said, "Also it's fun to feel like detectives, except the clues try to drown us."

Hollis laughed, a deep friendly sound. "Fair reasons all around."

After they'd warmed up, Hollis led them up the spiral stairs to the lantern room. Sunlight spilled through clean glass, and the lens assembly sparkled like a giant crystal eye.

Hollis patted the metal housing affectionately. "Brightsalute doesn't just warn. It greets."

Bram raised his pencil. "Light rhythm?"

Hollis struck a match, and as the day dimmed toward late afternoon, the lamp kindled. The mechanism began to rotate, and the beam turned outward.

Gold light swept the sea.

Then—three quick flashes.

Then one long, steady beam.

Then a pause.

Hollis watched Bram's face. "That's the salute. Three for 'hello,' one for 'safe passage.' My father designed it when he built the tower. Said sailors needed kindness as much as warnings."

Bram's throat tightened unexpectedly. He wrote carefully:
BRIGHTSALUTE—GOLD—FLASH FLASH FLASH, LONG, PAUSE. PURPOSE:
GREETING/SAFE PASSAGE.

He closed the notebook. The register was complete.

Down on the shore, the Gull's Grin waited like an eager dog, sails fluttering softly. The crew loaded supplies Hollis insisted on gifting—biscuits, fresh water, and a coil of new rope "because rope is cheaper than funerals."

As they prepared to leave, Hollis stood on the rocks by the lighthouse, raising his arm.

Bram climbed into the skiff, then looked back.

The lighthouse beam turned toward them as the mechanism rotated, and in the growing dusk it flashed—flash, flash, flash—then held a long golden glow that painted a path across the water straight to their boat.

It looked exactly like a wave, frozen into light.

A salute.

Lina waved so hard she nearly toppled over. "It's saying goodbye!"

Patch waved with both hands. “Goodbye, friendly tower! Please don’t ever become haunted!”

Old Nessa called, “Keep your lamp clean!”

Jory lifted his hand in a quiet, respectful gesture.

Bram stood in the skiff, hat pressed to his chest. He didn’t know when he’d started taking lighthouses personally, but he had. Maybe because they were proof that someone, somewhere, cared enough to stand in storms and keep a light burning for strangers.

“Thank you,” Bram said, though Hollis couldn’t possibly hear over the water.

The Gull’s Grin unfurled her sails. The sea, calmer now, rolled beneath them like a satisfied animal.

Bram opened his notebook one last time and looked at the pages filled with lights and warnings and small notes about people.

He’d set out to count lighthouses.

He’d ended up counting friends.

Behind them, Brightsalute’s golden beam swept the horizon once more—steady, warm, and brave—until fog and distance finally folded it away.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) What was Captain Bram's main reason for creating the register of the Secret Lantern Route?

- To collect lighthouses as trophies
- To help crews navigate safely and share knowledge
- To sell the locations to his pirate rivals
- To find treasure hidden under the lighthouses

2) Which lighthouse had a keeper named Mara and what problem did she face?

- Cindercap; the heat was melting the lamp
- Spindlewick; the wick kept fraying and the mechanism caught
- Gloomglass; the lens was stolen at night
- Brightsalute; the beam was too weak to be seen

3) How did the crew fix the overheating problem at Cindercap Lighthouse?

- They moved the lantern farther from the vent
- They wrapped a copper coil and cooled it with a slow trickle of water
- They replaced the oil with thicker oil
- They sealed the vents to stop hot air

4) What unusual thing did Bram use to help remove the black film from the lens at Gloomglass?

- A jar of volcanic ash from Cindercap
- Sea salt and lemon from the ship
- A cloth soaked in oil
- A bottle of fresh water

5) Which lighthouse's light pattern included a greeting of three quick flashes followed by one long beam, and who designed that salute?

- Spindlewick; Mara designed it
- Gloomglass; the original keeper designed it
- Brightsalute; Hollis said his father designed it
- Cindercap; Sato designed it

6) During the storm, how did the crew prevent Captain Bram from

falling overboard when the chart tube slipped?

- They used a grappling hook to hold him
- They threw a life ring and pulled him back
- Jory held his belt, Lina grabbed his sleeve, and Patch pinned his boot
- They tied him to the mast with a rope

Correct answers:

1) To help crews navigate safely and share knowledge 2) Spindlewick; the wick kept fraying and the mechanism caught 3) They wrapped a copper coil and cooled it with a slow trickle of water 4) A jar of volcanic ash from Cindercap 5) Brightsalute; Hollis said his father designed it 6) Jory held his belt, Lina grabbed his sleeve, and Patch pinned his boot

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Pewter: A dull gray metal that looks like old silver, used for cups and plates.

Crinkled: Wrinkled or creased, like paper that has been folded or squashed.

Rigging: All the ropes and lines on a ship that hold sails and masts up.

Stuttering: Stopping and starting in a quick way, like a light that flashes unevenly.

Sputtered: Made short, weak bursts of sound or flame, as a lamp that struggles.

Solemnly: In a very serious and quiet way, without joking.

Fathoms: A measure of water depth; one fathom equals six feet.

Vent: An opening that lets air or gas move in or out of a place.

Heat sink: Something that takes away and holds heat so things do not get too hot.

Prisms: Pieces of shaped glass that bend and spread light into beams.